

Look Ma!

Communication has gone from the personal face-to-face type to phones, then text chats and, thanks to broadband penetration, is now going audio/visual. Let's take a look at some webcams that will make your communication personal again

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In this age of "broadband," a webcam is an important accessory for most people with Internet connections. A lot of us have relatives and loved ones abroad, and webcams add that essential visual element that's missing from chat sessions or phone calls.

Businesses use videoconferencing to cut business deals without the need to be actually present face-to-face. They can also be used as security cameras to add that increased security for your home or office. Scientists have been

using webcams to provide video feeds from inaccessible places such as Antarctica, inside major volcanoes, etc. TV channels like Discovery, Animal Planet and National Geographic use them to make documentaries.

Some of us would have heard of a project by the National Geographic Society, called the Crittercam. This is a camera that's worn by an animal and captures video and audio to help us understand how animals behave in the wild.

Let's stick to the webcams we'll be using on our Desktops for now.

We received a total of 19 webcams

from Creative, Genius, Logitech, Microsoft, and Tech-Com. These were divided into two categories: PC webcams and laptop webcams. The PC Webcam category consisted of 13 cams, while five Laptop Webcams came in. The Logitech Orbit MP—a high-end webcam with a motorized drive—was tested separately, because it would have been unfair to compare it with the other, regular ones.

FEATURES Sensors

CCD sensors are still more expensive than CMOS sensors, and so it was no surprise that all the cameras had CMOS sensors. Of course, you should know that over the past few years, CMOS technology has improved by leaps and bounds, and now offers comparable quality at a lower price.

Most webcams in the PC category featured a maximum video resolution of 640 x 480. The two exceptions were the Creative Instant, which featured the lowest resolution of 352 x 288, and the

